

once). When doctors diagnose an illness, they don't just look at the individual symptoms to give them an idea of what's wrong and how to fix it – they look at how those symptoms relate to one another, what's exacerbating what. They ask you questions about your lifestyle – and if you've ever watched a medical drama, you'll know that some seemingly irrelevant aspect of the patient history almost always ends up being a critical detail. We really need to apply that context to our relationship with money if we want to figure out what went wrong, and what we can do to fix it.

Sometimes, we carry outdated ideas about our own ability to manage our money. Some financial mistakes come with a very long tail, meaning that even when your attitude and behaviour shift significantly in the intervening years, you can still be left dealing with the consequences of decisions that you made when you were much younger, and knew less about how things worked, or didn't have the perspective and life experience that you have now. It's really important to allow for growth in your money mindset, and dwelling on mistakes that you made years or sometimes even decades ago will keep you stuck in those limiting beliefs about your abilities.

Exercise: Identifying money mistakes

For the first exercise of this section, I'd like you to think about three money mistakes you've made. They might be big things, or smaller things, or absolutely minuscule